

Outdated answers, traced to their source

A synthetic incident in an internal vacation-policy assistant:
system map, diagnosis and recovery plan.

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1 • WHAT IS BROKEN

Outdated vacation answers from the policy assistant



Likely failure zone (inferred): the policy index, where ingestion hands policy content to serving.

Fact • synthetic case Symptom Q: “How many vacation days do I get per year?” A: “28 days”, citing <i>Vacation Policy 2025</i>. Expected: “29 days from 2026”, citing the 2026 policy.	Fact + unknown Impact Employees plan vacation with one day less than entitled. Scope beyond the reporter is unknown. Severity: medium, because HR approves every request.	Action taken today Containment Vacation-entitlement questions route to HR: “Please contact HR directly”. HR tells employees the correct 2026 entitlement.
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The old policy reached the model; the index is the suspect

Competing hypotheses, none verified

#	Hypothesis	Next test	Confidence
1	Missing ingestion: the 2026 policy never reached the index	Search the index for the 2026 policy; check the ingestion job	Medium
2	Version conflict: both versions indexed, no effective-date filter	Replay the question; inspect ranked passages and dates	Medium
3	Wrong metadata: 2026 policy tagged for another country or role	Replay as other roles; inspect the 2026 tags	Low
4	Stale cache: an old answer is served from cache	Replay with cache bypassed; check cache age	Low

Observed: key evidence

The answer cites *Vacation Policy 2025*: the old version reached the model, which used what it received.

Unknown: missing evidence

Retrieval logs, index contents, and how many employees are affected.

Next-best test

Inspect the 2026 policy and its tags in the index, then replay the question without cache. One test, four outcomes.

3 · WHAT WE RECOMMEND

Contain and investigate now, then correct

STEP 1

Contain

Route vacation questions to HR;
HR informs affected employees.

Owner: HR + AI/IT

STEP 2

Investigate

Index inspection and replay;
scope check of policies updated
since July.

Owner: AI/IT

STEP 3

Correct

Only the fix that matches
the test: re-ingest, retire the
old version, fix tags, or clear
the cache.

Owner: AI/IT, HR approves tags

STEP 4

Prevent

Publication check on every HR
release; the original failure
becomes a permanent test.

Owner: AI/IT + HR

Proof of recovery

5 phrasings of the original question: “29
days”, 2026 citation, 5/5. Index updated
within 1 day.

Release and rollback

One-week pilot. Any superseded citation or
permission violation → back to HR routing.

What would change this

Many stale policies or cross-role leaks →
pause the whole assistant.